

0.1 TAKE OVER

interactive in progress / extinction in progress

There is a church, except there isn't, because the thing we call a church turns out to contain at least two incompatible objects: the stone container and the people who once made the container mean something, and in these photographs the first has survived the second, which is already suspicious, because normally we speak as though institutions are the durable things and people are the passing things, whereas here the institution has literally become rubble and the people are absent and yet somehow the absence has more pressure than the masonry.

So: church minus ecclesia.

A shell after its assembly.

A room after the reason for the room has left.

Good starting condition.

TAKE OVER begins here, among abandoned churches, holes, tombstones, bits of marble, damaged geometry, light behaving like it knows more than we do, and a person who appears with a black square whose status is, initially, unclear. Object? Token? Signal? Error? Device? Offering? It is shown to the outside world. It is carried inward. It is placed somewhere. It reappears. At some point it acquires the visual grammar of a QR code, which is funny because the QR code is perhaps the most aggressively contemporary object imaginable, a bureaucratic little machine that says YOU MAY NOW LEAVE THIS PHYSICAL REALITY THROUGH YOUR TELEPHONE, and here it is sitting among funerary stones.

Which is not subtle.

Good.

The code is not there to explain the photograph. We are trying very hard not to explain the photograph, including right now, in a project description whose institutional purpose is unfortunately to explain the project.

This is the first contradiction.

Keep it.

The code opens another channel. A voice. A field recording. A sound made in the place. A person speaking back from inside an image in which they previously appeared to have no power except to be looked at. Then perhaps another person. Then another practice. Photography leaks.

Image → voice → sound → person → practice → relation → next.

This chain looks suspiciously neat when written like that.

Reality will presumably damage it.

That is part of the mechanism.

The word *ecclesia* matters here because before the church became an architectural object, institutional structure, hierarchy, theology, property portfolio and occasionally very impressive roof, *ekklesia* named an assembly. People called together. The people, not the building.

The abandoned church therefore presents an almost absurdly literal inversion: the architecture survives and the assembly has vanished.

TAKE OVER proposes to run the operation backward.

Not restoration.

Absolutely not restoration.

Nobody is rebuilding the lost congregation, agreeing on a doctrine, electing a supreme leader, or politely reproducing the social order whose remains are currently making such good photographs.

Instead:

remains → call → response → relation → assembly?

Question mark mandatory.

Because community is one of those words that starts dying the instant everybody agrees they are doing it.

A community is not a picture of several people standing near one another. It is not the word COMMUNITY printed in 48-point type at the entrance of an institution. It is not consensus. It might not even be pleasant.

It is a set of consequences produced by people becoming mutually available to one another.

Which brings us to the arithmetic.

The call permits fifteen photographs.

We have more than fifteen photographs.

So naturally we submit twelve.

$$12 + \square + \square + \square = 15$$

Three positions remain unallocated.

This is not minimalism.

It is not curatorial restraint.

It is not because somebody forgot to export three TIFFs.

The empty positions are occupied by the possibility that somebody not presently inside the project might alter it.

Twenty percent of scarce exhibition territory is therefore sacrificed to a person who does not exist yet, at least not for us.

Which is economically idiotic.

Which is why it means something.

The initial participants remain identifiable. KUMIORI brings one photographic trajectory. Ave Palm enters with another, abandoned architectures, bodies, movement, cyanotype. Mai-Brit Tånava is photographed, then speaks, which changes her position inside the apparatus from represented body to speaking agent. Kenn-Eerik Kannike introduces situated sound, electronic performance, listening.

Nobody gets dissolved into a soothing collective pronoun.

"We" is dangerous here.

We will use it anyway.

But carefully.

The work is not the sum of these contributions. The sum is trivial. Four people plus photographs plus audio plus a website does not automatically equal community any more than putting twelve strangers in a lift produces a political movement.

The work is what begins occurring between the elements.

$$\mathcal{W} = \{\text{image, voice, sound, body, practice}\} - \mathcal{R}$$

where $\mathcal{R}$ is the unstable part, the part nobody owns, the part that grows edges.

The exhibition begins on a wall because the wall is what Fotografiska gives us, but very quickly the wall becomes a problem.

Good.

Take over the wall.

Then go through it.

A photograph opens a sound. The sound opens a person. The person introduces a practice. A practice may become movement. Movement might become performance. Performance might require food. Food requires tables. Tables produce conversation. Conversation produces another person. Somebody brings a record. Somebody brings a projector. Somebody says this is ridiculous.

Excellent.

The exhibition has started working.

The opening therefore cannot simply be the ceremonial moment at which completed objects are admired beside beverages.

The opening is an activation.

Photography + voice + situated sound + movement.

After that, the sentence becomes conditional.

Maybe concert.

Maybe performance.

Maybe food.

Maybe night.

Maybe nothing we currently know how to name in the PDF, which is slightly inconvenient for a PDF but useful for an artwork.

The abandoned church remains underneath all of this as a warning.

Assemblies become institutions.

Institutions become architecture.

Architecture survives its assembly.

Then somebody finds the ruins.

We would like to interrupt that cycle somewhere before the part where the living thing becomes a mausoleum of itself.

So TAKE OVER does not ask how to build a permanent community.

It asks something more unstable:

How can an assembly form, act, alter its environment, and then pass something onward before becoming the thing that must later be taken over?

Take over the wall.

Take over the sound.

Take over the opening.

Take over the mechanism.

Then, crucially:

PASS IT ON.

TAKE OVER

interactive in progress / extinction in progress

There is a church.
More precisely, there is what remains of one.
Stone, apertures, funerary inscriptions, broken surfaces, light, acoustic cavities. An architecture whose original assembly has disappeared. The distinction matters because before *church* became the name of the building and of the institution, *ekklesia* named an assembly. People called together.
Here the architecture remains.
The ecclesia does not.
This is our initial condition.
TAKE OVER starts from what remains and asks what can happen next.
A photographic sequence moves through abandoned churches, bodies, openings and objects whose meaning changes frame to frame. A black square appears. At first it has no known function. It is exposed to the outside, carried, displaced, observed. It becomes signal, token, code, portal.
Nothing here is introduced to explain what came before.
The image does not explain the sound. The sound does not close the image. A voice does not resolve the photograph.
Each produces another possible direction.

image → voice → sound → person → practice → relation → next.

I come to this project from theoretical mechanics and applied mathematics, where I work on irreversible systems, instability, singular perturbations and forms of analysis that begin precisely where an algebraic description stops being enough. A small perturbation can leave the state almost unchanged. Or it can change the admissible trajectory completely. Once the system moves, returning to the previous state may no longer be possible.
I look at community in much the same way.
Not as an object. Not as a sum of individuals. Not as consensus.
As an evolving configuration of relations.
TAKE OVER therefore begins as an individual application and immediately develops a problem with remaining individual.
Ave Palm brings another photographic trajectory through abandoned architectures, bodies, movement and cyanotype. Mai-Brit Tănava first appears inside the image and then speaks from it. Kenn-Eerik Kannike introduces listening, field recording and electronic sound. Their contributions remain attributable. We are not trying to manufacture anonymous collective authorship.
What matters is what appears between them.

$$\mathcal{W} = \{\text{image, voice, sound, body, practice, . . .}\} + \mathcal{R},$$

with $\mathcal{R}$ the evolving set of relations that we cannot prescribe in advance.
This is where the project becomes a game.

Not a game in the sense that nothing is at stake. Quite the opposite.
The open call gives us a finite surface. Fifteen photographic positions.
We deliberately allocate twelve.

$$12 + \square + \square + \square = 15.$$

Three positions remain open.
Not because material is missing.
Because somebody is.
This is a small perturbation to the usual logic of an application. Instead of maximizing occupation of the available surface, we introduce vacancy as a condition for something else to enter. Twenty percent of the scarce photographic estate is therefore reserved for contributions that have not surfaced yet.
The vacancies are not outside the work.
They are active variables.
The exhibition starts from the wall. Photographs connect through QR portals to voices, field recordings, sound and an evolving digital surface. The wall is therefore not simply where the work is displayed.
The wall is an initial condition.
TAKE OVER goes through it.
The opening is the first activation: photography, voice, situated sound, movement. From there, according to the people and resources that enter the process, another trajectory may develop: live sound, performance, food, conversation, night.
These are not programme items to be filled.
Each practice enters because someone brings it.
This returns us to the abandoned church.
The old assembly has disappeared while its architecture survives. TAKE OVER does not propose to restore it. There is no common belief to recover and no previous order to reconstruct.
The question is different:
Can a new assembly emerge from the remains without reproducing the structure that preceded it?
Can people enter without being absorbed?
Can difference remain visible while relations grow?
Can an exhibition produce consequences beyond the object that initiated them?
In mechanics we would say that the trajectory is not known from the initial condition alone. Stability may be lost. Bifurcations appear. Constraints matter. History matters. Irreversibility matters.
Here too.
Someone enters. Something changes. Another possibility becomes admissible.
Then another person enters.
The configuration changes again.
TAKE OVER is therefore not a finished work waiting for an audience.
It is an initial condition looking for consequences.
TAKE OVER THE WALL. TAKE OVER THE OPENING. TAKE OVER THE SOUND. TAKE OVER WHAT FOLLOWS.
Then, crucially:
PASS IT ON.

1.1 TAKE OVER

interactive in progress / extinction in progress

There is, first of all, a church.

Or rather there is what remains of one, which is not quite the same thing, because a church without the people who made it a church is technically architecture, ruin, evidence, shell, acoustical cavity, cultural remainder, maybe real estate, but no longer quite *ecclesia*, the older word underneath the building, meaning not stone but assembly, not roof but people called together.

This distinction matters.

The photographs begin there, among abandoned churches, funerary stones, holes, fragments, apertures, bodies, objects whose function is not immediately obvious. At some point a black square appears. Nobody explains it. It is held up. Carried. Left behind. Encountered again. Eventually it becomes legible as something like a code, which is to say simultaneously an object and an instruction for leaving the object.

And this is approximately where TAKE OVER begins.

Not from nothing. Nothing is rarely available.

It begins from what remains: architectures, images, memories, relationships, sounds, debris, previous uses, dead people's names carved in stone, other people's photographs, somebody else's voice, the fact that someone has already stood here before you and altered the conditions under which you now arrive.

The QR code does not explain the photograph. This is important. The photograph has already done perfectly well without explanation. The code instead punctures it. Through it comes a voice, or a field recording, or sound gathered somewhere else, or another person altogether. Image opens to voice; voice to sound; sound to person; person to practice; practice to relation; relation to whatever happens next.

The point is not multimedia.

The point is contagion.

Community here is therefore not an object being photographed. Nor, ideally, a comforting noun pasted over a collection of people who already know one another. It is a process whose evidence consists in the fact that something passes.

And because this is a Community Gallery open call, with the peculiar arithmetic common to open calls in which many people enter and very few physically fit through the institutional aperture, TAKE OVER introduces one small perturbation.

Fifteen photographic positions are available.

We use twelve.

$$12 + \square + \square + \square = 15$$

The remaining three are not empty because we ran out of photographs. We have pho-

tographs.

They are empty because somebody is not here yet.

This is the proposition in its least metaphorical form: twenty percent of scarce exhibition space is surrendered in advance to people, works or relations we cannot presently name. If nobody enters, the vacancy remains visible. If somebody does, the work changes.

The initial constellation is small. Andrés A. León Baldelli / KUMIORI brings the photographic sequence. Ave Palm brings another photographic language through abandoned architectures, bodies, movement and cyanotype. Mai-Brit Tånava enters first as a photographed body and then, crucially, as a voice capable of speaking back from inside the image. Kenn-Eerik Kannike introduces listening, site recordings and the possibility of live electronic sound.

Nobody disappears into a collective signature.

That would defeat the point.

The authors remain authors. Their works remain theirs. What TAKE OVER claims as its material is what begins occurring **between** them.

This returns us to the church.

The Greek *ekklesia* named an assembly before it named the architectural container we now instinctively picture when somebody says "church." In these photographs the historical inversion is almost embarrassingly literal: the container survives and the assembly is gone. So what happens if the process is run backward?

$$\text{remains} + \text{call} \rightarrow \text{response} \rightarrow \text{assembly}$$

Not an assembly of people who believe the same thing.

That would be easy, and historically rather dangerous.

An assembly of people willing to respond.

The exhibition is therefore less a finished configuration than an initial condition. Photographs occupy the wall. Certain photographs contain portals. Portals lead to voices, sounds, people, translations, invitations, and to a live digital surface where the project's trajectory, needs, resources and emerging relations remain visible.

Then comes the opening.

Photography. Voice. Situated sound. Movement.

Possibly a concert. Possibly performance. Possibly food. Possibly night. None of these are decorative programme extensions appended afterward to make the opening "immersive." They enter only if someone enters carrying them.

Which means the exhibition can exceed its wall without pretending the wall does not matter.

The wall is the initial condition.

The opening perturbs it.

And then, ideally, something we did not authorize happens.

TAKE OVER THE WALL. TAKE OVER THE SOUND. TAKE OVER THE OPENING. PASS IT ON.

Because a takeover that ends in possession is merely conquest.

The interesting version is transmission.

1.2 TAKE OVER

interactive in progress / extinction in progress

A church is first a building. Then it is an image of a building. Then, perhaps, it is again an assembly.

TAKE OVER begins with abandoned churches: emptied architectures, funerary stones, apertures, bodies, fragments. What has disappeared is as important as what remains.

The word *eclesia* once named an assembly before it named its architectural enclosure. Here the enclosure persists. The assembly is absent.

This absence is not neutral.

A ruin is never merely empty. It is occupied by history, memory, abandonment, previous uses, previous beliefs. To photograph it is already to enter into relation with what is no longer present.

Into these spaces comes a black square.

At first it is opaque. Then it becomes object, signal, code, portal. It passes from hand to hand, image to image. Its meaning is not fixed by appearance. It changes through use.

The QR code extends this operation. It does not explain the photograph. Explanation would close the image too quickly. Instead, the code opens the image onto another medium: voice, field recording, sound, another person.

Photography becomes porous.

Image opens to voice. Voice opens to sound. Sound opens to another person. Another person brings another practice.

The work is not only what is shown.

The work is also what passes between what is shown.

Community, in this sense, is not a subject represented by photographs. It is not the warm image of togetherness. It is a structure of relations, provisional and unstable.

The question is not: *What do these people have in common?*

The question is: *What can they make possible for one another?*

The application itself accepts this risk.

Fifteen photographic positions are available. Twelve are initially occupied.

$$12 + \square + \square + \square = 15$$

Three remain open.

The emptiness is deliberate. The vacancies are not evidence of incompleteness. They are a refusal to confuse completeness with saturation.

To leave space is also an action.

The initial participants retain their names, their authorship, their differences. Andrés A. León Baldelli / KUMIORI brings the photographic sequence. Ave Palm introduces another photographic language through abandoned architecture, bodies, movement and cyanotype. Mai-Brit Tånava appears first as an image and then speaks from within it. Kenn-Erik Kannike extends the project through situated sound and live electronic performance.

The collective does not require anonymity.

Difference is not an obstacle to community. It is its material.

The exhibition begins on the wall, but the wall is not its limit.

Photographs connect to voices. Voices connect to sound. Sound may become performance. Performance may become gathering. Food, movement, night, translation, conversation may enter later.

Not because an exhibition must become “immersive.”

Because one medium may create the conditions for another.

The wall is the initial condition.

The opening alters it.

The public alters it again.

The abandoned church offers the project its central image: an architecture whose original assembly has vanished.

TAKE OVER asks whether another assembly can form there without pretending to restore the old one.

Not resurrection.

Recomposition.

Not consensus.

Response.

Not possession.

Transmission.

TAKE OVER THE WALL. TAKE OVER THE OPENING. TAKE OVER THE SOUND. PASS IT ON.